机器人服务员

孙爷爷和一碗汤

The Robot Waiter

Grandpa Sun and a bowl of soup

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 3 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 孙[†]爷爷今年七十二岁，是一个很爱说话的老人。他每天早上去公园，中午回家自己做饭，晚上看电视。他不太喜欢新东西：他用手机只打电话，买东西一定要给现金。

我不去

2 这个星期六是孙爷爷的生日。孙子[‡]浩浩[§]给他打电话：“爷爷，我们家旁边新开了一家饭馆，听说菜很好吃，并且服务员是机器人[¶]！星期六我请您去那里吃饭吧。”“什么？机器人当服务员？”孙爷爷在电话里大声说，“这简直是开玩笑！我不去。”

3 浩浩以为爷爷只是说说，可是爷爷是认真的。浩浩又说了很多：那里的机器人会说话，会唱歌，走得很快……

† 孙 *Sūn* Sun (surname)

‡ 孙子 *sūnzi* grandson

§ 浩浩 *Hàohao* Haohao, Grandpa Sun's grandson

¶ 机器人 *jīqìrén* robot

Grandpa Sun is seventy-two this year, an old man who loves to talk. Every morning he goes to the park, at noon he goes home and cooks for himself, and in the evening he watches TV. He isn't fond of new things: he uses his phone only for calls, and when he buys something he always pays in cash. 1

I'm Not Going

This Saturday is Grandpa Sun's birthday. His grandson Haohao phoned him. "Grandpa, a new restaurant has opened near our place. I hear the food is very good, and the waiter is a robot! Let me take you there for a meal on Saturday." "What? A robot as a waiter?" Grandpa Sun said loudly into the phone. "That's simply a joke! I'm not going." 2

Haohao thought Grandpa was just saying so, but Grandpa meant it. Haohao told him a lot more: the robot there could talk, it could sing, it moved fast... 3

3 爷爷还是说：“饭是人做的，菜也应该是人送来的。机器人[†]懂什么？它知道菜热不热吗？它知道客人高兴不高兴吗？不去，我不去！”

4 星期六中午，浩浩[‡]来到爷爷家，什么也没说，拉起爷爷的手就往外走：“今天您过生日，就听我一次吧。”爷爷没有办法，只好跟着他出了门。路上，他一直以为，机器人服务员一定像电影里那样，是一个铁做的大个子，说话的声音很奇怪。

会说话的机器人

5 饭馆不大，可是很干净，客人也不少。门口没有服务员，只有一个白色的机器人。它跟一个十岁的孩子差不多高，身上有三层，每层都可以放菜；头上是一个小电脑，上面有两只大大的眼睛。

† 机器人 *jīqìrén* robot

‡ 浩浩 *Hàohao* Haohao, Grandpa Sun's grandson

But Grandpa still said, "Food is cooked by people, and it ought to be brought by people too. What does a robot understand? Does it know whether the food is hot? Does it know whether the customer is happy? No, I'm not going!" 3

At noon on Saturday, Haohao came to Grandpa's home, said nothing, took Grandpa by the hand and headed out the door. "It's your birthday today. Just listen to me this once." Grandpa had no choice but to follow him out. All the way there, he assumed a robot waiter would be like the ones in films: a big fellow made of iron with a strange voice. 4

The Talking Robot

The restaurant wasn't big, but it was very clean, and there were quite a few customers. There was no waiter at the door, only a white robot. It was about as tall as a ten-year-old child. Its body had three shelves, each of which could hold dishes, and its head was a small computer with two big eyes on it. 5

5 看见他们进来，机器人[†]的眼睛笑成了两个弯弯[‡]的月亮：“欢迎！欢迎！我是豆豆[§]。两位请这边坐！”它的声音像一个小女孩。爷爷看了它半天，没说出话来。

6 桌子上没有菜单，只有一张小纸，上面有一个二维码[¶]。浩浩[*]拿出手机扫[#]了一下，手机上马上出现了很多菜的照片。“爷爷，您想吃什么，在这里点一下就行了。点好以后用手机付钱，并且不用等服务员过来。”爷爷看了看手机，说：“这么小的字，我简直一个也看不清楚。你点吧，我要一条鱼，再来一碗鸡汤。”

7 没过几分钟，豆豆就来了。它走得很快，前面有人的时候，它就停下来说：“请让一让，谢谢！”到了桌子旁边，它说：“您好，您的鱼来了，请把菜拿下去吧。”

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† 机器人 *jīqìrén* robot
‡ 弯弯 *wānwān* curved
§ 豆豆 *Dòudou* Doudou (the robot's name)
¶ 二维码 *èrwéimǎ* QR code
* 浩浩 *Hàohao* Haohao, Grandpa Sun's grandson
扫 *sǎo* to scan

When it saw them come in, the robot's eyes curved into two smiling crescent moons. "Welcome! Welcome! I'm Doudou. This way please, both of you!" Its voice was like a little girl's. Grandpa stared at it for a long time and couldn't get a word out. 5

There was no menu on the table, only a small card with a QR code on it. Haohao took out his phone and scanned it, and pictures of lots of dishes appeared on the phone at once. "Grandpa, whatever you want to eat, just tap it here. Once you've ordered, you pay with your phone, and you don't have to wait for a waiter to come over." Grandpa looked at the phone and said, "Such small characters, I can hardly read a single one. You order. I'll have a fish, and a bowl of chicken soup too." 6

Only a few minutes later, Doudou arrived. It moved quickly, and whenever there was someone in front of it, it stopped and said, "Excuse me, please let me through, thank you!" When it reached the table, it said, "Hello, here is your fish. Please take the dish down." 7

浩浩[†]把鱼拿到桌子上，又笑着拍了拍豆豆[‡]的头。豆豆马上说：“别拍我的头，我会长不高的！”爷爷听了，哈哈大笑起来。

浩浩告诉爷爷，这几年，中国很多城市都有了这样的机器人[§]。在饭馆里，它们给客人送菜；在酒店里，它们会自己坐电梯[¶]，把客人要的东西送到房间门口。“机器人不会累，也不用休息，并且一个机器人一天能送很多很多菜。”浩浩说。爷爷吃了一口鱼，味道果然很不错。他看着跑来跑去的豆豆，说：“这个小东西还挺有意思。”

汤

十二点半，饭馆里的人越来越多，每张桌子都坐满了。浩浩这才发现，这么大的饭馆，只有一个真人服务员。

† 浩浩 *Hàohao* Haohao, Grandpa Sun's grandson

‡ 豆豆 *Dòudou* Doudou (the robot's name)

§ 机器人 *jīqìrén* robot

¶ 电梯 *diàntī* lift, elevator

Haohao lifted the fish onto the table, then gave Doudou a pat on the head with a smile. Doudou said at once, "Don't pat my head, I won't grow any taller!" Grandpa burst out laughing. 7

Haohao told Grandpa that in the last few years robots like this had appeared in many Chinese cities. In restaurants they bring customers their food; in hotels they take the lift on their own and deliver what guests have asked for to the door of their room. "Robots don't get tired, they don't need a rest, and one robot can deliver lots and lots of dishes in a day," said Haohao. Grandpa took a bite of the fish. Sure enough, it tasted very good. He watched Doudou bustling back and forth and said, "This little thing is quite interesting." 8

The Soup

By half past twelve the restaurant was getting more and more crowded, and every table was full. Only then did Haohao notice that a restaurant this big had just one human waiter. 9

9 她叫小方[†]，二十多岁，一会儿跑到这张桌子帮老人点菜，一会儿跑到那张桌子回答问题，一会儿又去门口送客人，忙得连喝口水的时间都没有。

10 这时候，豆豆[‡]送来了爷爷点的鸡汤。那是很大的一碗汤，还很热。豆豆走到一半，前面突然跑过来一个小男孩。豆豆马上停了下来："请让一让，谢谢！"小男孩觉得很好玩，不但没有走开，还站在它前面跟它玩。豆豆往左走，小男孩也往左走；豆豆往右走，小男孩也往右走。

11 豆豆转来转去，最后突然不动了，头上的两只大眼睛变成了两个问号。它停得太快了，那一大碗汤从它身上掉了下来，地上一下全是汤，小男孩的鞋上也都是。还好没有人受伤，可是小男孩大哭起来。豆豆还在一遍一遍地说："出了一点儿问题，请找服务员。出了一点儿问题，请找服务员。"饭馆里简直乱成了一片。

† 小方 *Xiǎo Fāng* Xiao Fang, the waitress

‡ 豆豆 *Dòudou* Doudou (the robot's name)

She was called Xiao Fang, and she was in her twenties. One moment she was running to this table to help an old person order, the next to that table to answer a question, then to the door to see customers out. She was so busy she didn't even have time for a sip of water. 9

Just then, Doudou came with the chicken soup Grandpa had ordered. It was a very big bowl of soup, and still hot. Doudou was halfway there when a little boy suddenly ran out in front of it. Doudou stopped at once. "Please let me through, thank you!" The little boy thought this was great fun. Instead of moving away, he stood in front of it and played with it. When Doudou went left, the little boy went left too; when Doudou went right, the little boy went right too. 10

Doudou turned this way and that, and finally it suddenly stopped moving. The two big eyes on its head turned into two question marks. It had stopped too fast. The big bowl of soup fell off it, and in a moment the floor was covered in soup, and so were the little boy's shoes. Luckily no one was hurt, but the little boy burst into loud tears. Doudou kept saying, over and over, "There is a small problem, please call a waiter. There is a small problem, please call a waiter." The whole restaurant was in total chaos. 11

12 爷爷看了看浩浩[†]，说：“你看，果然出问题了吧！我早就说过，机器就是机器。”服务员小方[‡]在饭馆那边忙着给客人找钱，听到了也走不过来，只能大声说：“对不起，请等一下！我马上就来！”这时候，孙[§]爷爷站了起来。

13 他先走过去，把小男孩带到一边，拿纸把他的鞋弄干净，又笑着说：“别哭，别哭，机器人[¶]也会生病的。”小男孩不哭了。然后，爷爷走到出菜的地方，看到那里放着好几个做好的菜，可是没有人送。他看了看菜上的桌号，一只手拿两个，很快就把菜送到了客人的桌子上。他走得很快，可是碗里的汤一点儿也没有倒出来。

14 浩浩简直不敢相信自己的眼睛。他一直以为爷爷只会在家做饭、看电视，从来不知道爷爷还有这样的本事。小方忙完了，跑过来问：“爷爷，您以前做过这个工作吧？”

† 浩浩 *Hàohao* Haohao, Grandpa Sun's grandson

‡ 小方 *Xiǎo Fāng* Xiao Fang, the waitress

§ 孙 *Sūn* Sun (surname)

¶ 机器人 *jīqìrén* robot

Grandpa looked at Haohao and said, "See? Just as I thought, something's 12
gone wrong! I told you so: a machine is just a machine." Xiao Fang the waitress was busy giving a customer change at the far end of the restaurant. She heard, but she couldn't get away, and could only call out, "Sorry, please wait a moment! I'll be right there!" At that moment, Grandpa Sun stood up.

First he went over, led the little boy to one side, wiped his shoes clean with a 13
napkin, and said with a smile, "Don't cry, don't cry. Robots get sick sometimes too." The little boy stopped crying. Then Grandpa went over to where the food came out of the kitchen, and saw several finished dishes waiting there with no one to take them out. He checked the table numbers on the dishes, took two in each hand, and quickly carried them to the customers' tables. He walked fast, yet not a drop of soup spilled from the bowls.

Haohao could hardly believe his eyes. He had always thought Grandpa 14
could only cook at home and watch TV. He'd never known Grandpa had skills like this. When Xiao Fang was free, she ran over and asked, "Grandpa, you've done this job before, haven't you?"

14 爷爷笑了：“我年轻的时候，在国营[†]饭店当了三十年服务员。那时候，一个人要管十几张桌子，也没有机器人[‡]帮忙！”

下个星期

15 吃完饭，豆豆[§]已经被修好了，又在饭馆里跑来跑去。饭馆的经理走过来，一定不要他们的钱。爷爷不同意，还是让浩浩[¶]付了钱。走的时候，他对经理说：“机器人是好东西，走得快，不会累，并且还会讲笑话。”“可是它看不见孩子哭，也不知道老人为什么站在门口不进来。你们这里不是机器人太多了，是人太少了。”经理点点头：“您说得对，我们正在找人。”

16 回家的路上，浩浩问：“爷爷，下次还来吗？”

† 国营 *guóyíng* state-run

‡ 机器人 *jīqìrén* robot

§ 豆豆 *Dòudou* Doudou (the robot's name)

¶ 浩浩 *Hàohao* Haohao, Grandpa Sun's grandson

Grandpa smiled. "When I was young, I was a waiter at a state-run restaurant for thirty years. Back then, one person had to look after a dozen or more tables, and there were no robots to help, either!" 14

The Next Week

By the time they had finished eating, Doudou had been fixed and was bustling around the restaurant again. The restaurant manager came over and insisted on not taking their money. Grandpa wouldn't hear of it and still had Haohao pay. As they left, he said to the manager, "Robots are good things. They're fast, they don't get tired, and they can even tell jokes." "But it can't see a child crying, and it doesn't know why an old person is standing at the door and not coming in. Your problem here isn't too many robots, it's too few people." The manager nodded. "You're right. We're looking for people now." 15

On the way home, Haohao asked, "Grandpa, will you come again next time?" 16

16 “不来了！”爷爷说，“机器人[1]把汤送到地上的饭馆，有什么好来的？”可是下个星期六中午，浩浩[2]给爷爷打电话，没有人接。他想了想，就去了那家饭馆。果然，爷爷正坐在上次那张桌子旁边，跟小方[3]有说有笑[4]。豆豆[5]走过来，眼睛又笑成了两个弯弯[6]的月亮：“孙[7]爷爷，欢迎回来！今天我会小心的！”

17 浩浩笑着坐下来：“爷爷，您不是说不来了吗？”爷爷喝了一口茶，说：“我不是来吃饭的。我是来看看，这个小东西今天会不会又把汤送到地上。”浩浩看了看桌子上的三个菜和一碗鸡汤，什么也没说。

1 机器人 *jīqìrén* robot
2 浩浩 *Hàohao* Haohao, Grandpa Sun's grandson
3 小方 *Xiǎo Fāng* Xiao Fang, the waitress
4 有说有笑 *yǒushuō yǒuxiào* chatting and laughing
5 豆豆 *Dòudou* Doudou (the robot's name)
6 弯弯 *wānwān* curved
7 孙 *Sūn* Sun (surname)

"No, I won't!" said Grandpa. "A restaurant where the robot serves your soup onto the floor? What's the point of going there?" But at noon the following Saturday, Haohao phoned Grandpa and nobody answered. He thought for a moment, then went to that restaurant. Sure enough, there was Grandpa, sitting at the same table as last time, chatting and laughing with Xiao Fang. Doudou came over, its eyes curved into two crescent moons again. "Grandpa Sun, welcome back! I'll be careful today!" 16

Haohao sat down with a grin. "Grandpa, didn't you say you weren't coming back?" Grandpa took a sip of tea and said, "I haven't come to eat. I've come to see whether this little thing is going to serve the soup onto the floor again today." Haohao looked at the three dishes and the bowl of chicken soup on the table, and said nothing. 17